

CARLA VARONA CERVANTES

Banco Central de Chile | Agustinas 1180, Santiago, Chile | cvarona@bcentral.cl

Fields: Macroeconomics · Labor Economics · International Economics · Human Capital · Gender Economics

Research: dynamic models of educational choice with labor market information frictions (gender gaps, OECD) · dynastic GE-OLG models with administrative microdata (talent misallocation, Chile)

AFFILIATION

Banco Central de Chile — Monetary Policy Division, Economic Analysis Department

Senior Economist, October 2023 – Present

EDUCATION

European University Institute — Ph.D. in Economics 2023

Dissertation: "Essays in Economics of Education, Gender and Labor Economics"

Advisors: Russell Cooper and Alexander Monge-Naranjo

European University Institute — MRes. in Economics 2019

Universidad Carlos III de Madrid — M.A. in Economics 2018

Universidad Carlos III de Madrid — B.A. in Economics 2015

PUBLICATIONS

"Labor Market Implications of Education Mismatch"

Varona Cervantes, Carla, and Russell Cooper. *European Economic Review*, 148 (2022): 104179.

"Determining Gender Differences in Education and Labor Market Outcomes"

Joint with Russell Cooper. Forthcoming. *The Economic Journal*.

WORKING PAPERS

"Implications of Policy Interventions on Eliminating Gender Gaps"

Working Paper, 2026. Submitted.

Abstract: *This paper studies policy interventions intended to eliminate gender differences in labor market outcomes, principally wages. Because gender is an individual attribute rather than a manipulable treatment, the ideal experiment of randomly assigning gender to evaluate its effects is infeasible. Policies that remove gender labels from the employment process are the closest feasible counterpart. We quantify both the intended and unintended consequences of the policies through simulated interventions of an estimated equilibrium model of statistical discrimination with dynamic choices of education and labor market participation. In the short run the policy that requires gender free applications in the market for skilled labor eliminates wage gaps but once education choices respond the effects are attenuated. A more comprehensive policy that enforces gender free compensation reverses the wage gap in skilled markets and eliminates it in unskilled labor markets, even once education adjusts. These interventions impact college rates, the college premium gap and participation rates as well. The final section studies these interventions using a difference-in-differences (DID) approach to analyze the simulated data. With education fixed, the DID method recovers the policy effects but this is not the case once education adjusts, reflecting the effects of the intervention on both treated and control groups through equilibrium adjustments in beliefs.*

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Human Capital Misallocation and General Equilibrium Effects"

Joint with Agustín Díaz and Nadim Elayan-Balagué. Work in Progress, 2026.

Abstract: *We analyze the general equilibrium effects of human capital misallocation in Chile using linked administrative tax, education, and test-score data. We document substantial educational mismatch, with high-ability students from low-income families under-attending college, and we estimate sizable complementarities between ability, schooling, and labor-market outcomes. We build and calibrate a dynastic overlapping-generations (OLG) model featuring borrowing constraints, parental altruism, and both private and public educational investment — integrating K–12 school quality and college choice in a unified general equilibrium framework. The model is estimated via Simulated Method of Moments using administrative microdata linking tax records, educational outcomes, and standardized test scores for a cohort followed from age 10 through age 28. We use the estimated model to quantify the aggregate output, inequality, and intergenerational mobility effects of policies targeting credit constraints and school quality.*

"Employment Contract Rigidity and Technology Adoption in Chile"

Joint with Jeanne Lafortune and Jose Tessada (Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile) and Dagoberto Quevedo (Central bank of Chile). Work in Progress, 2026.

Abstract: *Chilean labor law restricts unilateral changes to contractually specified job functions, potentially constraining firms' ability to reallocate workers across tasks when adopting new technologies. We classify administrative employment contracts from the Dirección del Trabajo according to how adaptably job functions are defined, using large language models, and combine this classification with firm-level data to assess whether contractual rigidity slows technology adoption.*

"Labor Market Transitions and Job-to-Job Mobility in Chile"

Joint with external researcher (Banco Central de Chile). Work in Progress. BCCh Documento de Trabajo, expected December 2026.

Abstract: *Descriptive analysis of job-to-job transitions in Chile, focusing on transitions associated with wage cuts, voluntary vs. involuntary separations, tenure profiles, and wage growth at origin vs. destination firms. Uses administrative microdata from the Banco Central de Chile.*

POLICY WORK

Employment Dynamics in Chile: Administrative Data vs. INE Survey 2024–2025

Series of internal reports (joint with Matías Tapia and Montserrat Martí) comparing formal private-sector employment trends from administrative records (AFC) against the National Employment Survey (ENE). Identified and explained systematic divergences in levels and growth rates across demographic groups, nationality, and sectors, with policy implications for employment measurement in Chile.

Post-Pandemic Labor Market Dynamics: International Evidence and the Case of Chile 2026

Discussion Note (joint with Brian Pustilnik and Nadim Elayan-Balagué, GEE/GAI). Systematic review of international labor market evidence post-COVID-19 across OECD economies, benchmarked against Chile's anomalous pattern of rising real wages alongside weak employment creation. Presented to senior management, May 2026.

Gender Gaps in Chile: Briefing for the President of the Central Bank 2024

Prepared analysis on gender gaps in labor and credit markets in Chile using administrative data, including regression-adjusted wage gap estimates and mobility differentials. Presented to the President of the Banco Central de Chile.

IMF Article IV Comments on Chile and Gender 2024

Provided technical comments on gender-related annexes for the IMF Article IV consultation on Chile.

Effects of Working-Hours Reduction on Employment and Wages: Literature Review 2024

Synthesized international evidence on the employment and wage effects of mandatory reductions in working hours across France, Germany, Canada, Chile, and Sweden. Prepared as a briefing for the Board of the Banco Central de Chile.

PAST WORK EXPERIENCE

Associate Instructor — NYU Abu Dhabi, UAE 2022–2023

TEACHING

Numerical Methods (M.A. in Economics) — NYUAD Spring 2023

Macroeconomics II (M.A. in Economics) — NYUAD Spring & Fall 2023

Economic Policy (Undergraduate) — NYUAD Fall 2023

International Economics (Undergraduate) — NYU Florence Spring 2022

Macro and International Economics II (M.A. in Transnational Governance) — EUI Spring 2022

Macroeconomics III: Incomplete Markets (Ph.D.) — EUI Spring 2021

GRANTS, AWARDS AND HONORS

Ph.D. Fellowship, Salvador de Madariaga — Spanish Ministry of Education 2018–2022

Ph.D. Completion Grant — European University Institute 2021–2022

General Scholarship for Post-Compulsory Studies — Spanish Ministry of Education 2012–2015

PRESENTATIONS

Computing in Economics and Finance (CEF), Venice, 2026 [scheduled].

Jornadas de Economía Laboral, Málaga, 2026 [scheduled].

Midwest Macroeconomics Meetings, Richmond, VA, 2024.

LACEA Annual Meeting, Montevideo, 2024.

Gender Gaps Conference, Warsaw, 2024.

37th Congress of the European Economic Association (EEA-ESEM), 2022.

Barcelona School of Economics Summer Forum; XXX Meeting of the Economics of Education Association; ECO-EUI Education Conference; Lisbon Economics and Statistics of Education; Brown Bag Seminar, NYUAD.

LANGUAGES & NATIONALITY

Languages: English (fluent), Spanish (native), Italian (advanced).

Nationality: Cuban, Spanish.